

Academic Embedded Librarianship



A Brief History
Current State of the Field
Professional Resources
And More!

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What Is Embedded Librarianship?

WE GET OUT OF THE LIBRARY AND INTO THE COMMUNITY!

Would you like to contribute to the evolution of university life by meeting students and faculty where they are as an embedded academic librarian? Branching out from the trunk of the campus library to classrooms and other places students gather is an exciting way to foster curiosity and bring new insights to the field of librarianship.

“WHEN WE BEGIN TO INNOVATE, WE CAN CALL THE CHANGE INTO EXISTENCE, AND BEGIN DOING.” - MICHELLE REALE, 2016

Embedded academic librarians get to “explore new territories outside the library and take new opportunities to build working relationships—true collaboration and partnerships with our customers—as [they’ve] never been able to do in the past” (Rudin, 2008).

A Brief History

Being an embedded librarian is a fairly modern endeavor. Historically, university libraries held large collections for different areas of study that each began as smaller, personal collections professors kept for their own seminars (Drewes & Hoffman, 2010). As these collections grew, branch libraries became necessary and the associated branch librarians trained to develop subject matter specialization out of necessity to assist with research (Drewes & Hoffman, 2010). Branch librarians started to see themselves as more than just simple bibliographic resource fixtures and those specializing in medical research boldly joined doctors during their rounds. Doctors, as information seekers, recognized the value of having direct access to knowledge that helped them do their jobs (Drewes & Hoffman, 2010). Eventually, librarians who specialized in areas of the law, social sciences, music, technology, art, and more immersed themselves into classrooms, student unions, health facilities, and other campus spaces where information needs abound. Traditional academic librarians have been challenged by a steady decrease in reference requests, declining circulation totals, and the growing need for libraries to serve in less traditional ways. In light of these truths, library design has adapted to recognize students’ changing needs. Academic libraries began to provide comfortable spaces for studying, connecting to Wi-Fi, safely meeting with others, and grabbing a quick bite at the library café. Despite this evolving landscape, embedded and satellite librarians are sustained by their ability and willingness to operate within a new framework for their practice (Rudin, 2008).

WHAT COURSES SHOULD I TAKE?

- LIS 4000 Foundations of Library, Archival, & Information Science
- LIS 4010 Organization of Information
- LIS 4015 User & Access Services
- LIS 4040 Management of Information Organizations
- LIS 4050 Library & Information Technologies
- RMS 4900 Educational Research & Measurement
- LIS 4901 Capstone Or LIS 4910 Culminating Internship
- LIS 4005 Privilege & Equity
- LIS 4011 Information Access & Retrieval
- LIS 4043 Advocacy & Marketing
- LIS 4060 Reference
- LIS 4070 Cataloging & Classification
- LIS 4206 Web Content Management
- LIS 4320 Outreach
- LIS 4321 Collection Management
- LIS 4330 Information Literacy Instruction

ASSOCIATIONS & ORGANIZATIONS

- ACRL: Association of College & Research Libraries (Division of ALA)
www.ala.org/acrl
- ARL: Association of Research Libraries
www.arl.org
- LITA: Library & Information Technology Association
www.ala.org/lita
- ASIS: American Society for Information Sciences
www.asisonline.org

PUBLICATIONS & E-RESOURCES

- Book: *Becoming an Embedded Librarian: Making Connections in the Classroom* by Michelle Reale
- Book: *Virtually Embedded: The Librarian in an Online Environment* by Elizabeth Leonard & Erin McCaffrey
- Book: *Embedded Librarians: Moving Beyond One-Shot Instruction* by Cassandra Kvenild & Kaijsa Calkins
- Website: *American Libraries Magazine* -
www.americanlibrariesmagazine.org
- Website: *I Need a Library Job - Library & LIS Jobs* -
www.inalj.com



WHERE ARE ACADEMIC EMBEDDED LIBRARIANS NOW?

Academic librarians are contemporarily embedded in programs and classrooms across a wide variety of fields of study. From law to medicine, from fine arts to business, from engineering to natural sciences, embedded librarians have discovered the importance of forming stronger relationships with students and faculty. Moving beyond the traditional orientation-style introductory instruction methods, embedded academic librarians are helping students maintain the research skills required to succeed academically by being partners along their path, addressing library users' needs in a timely manner, being present and involved in the spaces students occupy, and by gaining a deeper understanding of their subject specialties (Reale, 2016). Michelle Reale, a librarian embedded in an English program at Arcadia University in Glenside, Pennsylvania, reflects on the juxtaposition between current opportunities to embed and the limitations of more traditional library settings:

"Things that happen on the edge are exciting—the unique position that librarians have in the classroom sets the stage for innovation, deep involvement, cooperation, collaboration, and assessment. This is difficult, if not impossible, to do in the limited and often random interactions we have not only with students, but with faculty as well" (Reale, 2016).

If you think you'd enjoy working in a cooperative academic environment, then embedded librarianship is a worthwhile career to explore. Not only are academic librarians getting out of the library and into classrooms, but they are also collaborating in administrative spaces. During the interview process, liaison librarians are meeting with faculty applicants with the goal of strengthening the professional group dynamics of educational teams (Budzise-Weaver & Bales, 2019). There are varying degrees of embeddedness and you'll come across different terminology like outreach librarian, library ambassador, library liaison, consulting librarian, etc. but all these positions have one thing in common: embedded academic librarians experience the opportunity to benefit from the collective knowledge of the settings they participate in.

"Regardless of the extent to which a librarian is 'embedded', they must see themselves as learners, too, as they develop their understanding of the disciplines they support through an ongoing process of experiencing, reflecting, conceptualizing and testing in their practice" (Luca, 2019).

If you came to the field of Library and Information Science in the hopes of connecting people to the information they need to excel and you like partnering with others who have similar, education-minded goals, then academic embedded librarianship is a good space for you!

"After all, the library is about people, for the people, and managed by the people. This democratic construct thrives when the library succeeds in connecting and engaging in positive relationships that impact the wellbeing and success of students" (Adeogun, 2022).



EDUCATION, SKILLS, & QUALIFICATIONS

- Master of Library Science from an ALA accredited institution
- Ability to build and sustain effective working relationships and work collaboratively in a diverse setting across constituencies including students, university faculty, staff, and administration
- Knowledge of how to provide user-centered service in an academic institution contributing to library and university goals
- Commitment to the values of diversity, equity, and inclusion
- Knowledge of reference and information sources, instruction methods, and library tools used for performing research
- Outstanding interpersonal, written, and oral communication skills
- Commitment to maintaining knowledge of emerging technologies, trends, issues, and skills associated with information and digital literacy
- Strong organizational, cross-organizational, analytical, qualitative, quantitative, and problem solving skills
- Flexibility to work successfully with different outreach modalities via various outreach related services



Do you want to make information more accessible? Do you want to have a positive impact on the minds and lives of students?

Then we encourage you to read more about

Academic Embedded Librarianship today! For more information, please visit:

www.libraryjournal.com/story/embedded-librarianship-the-future-of-libraries

www.ala.org/acrl/standards/outreach

crln.acrl.org/index.php/crlnews/article/view/24813/32645

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